

## IMPACT AT A GLANCE YTD

- 68K Service Members & Families Engaged
- 191 Military Installations
- 22 Countries
- 28 U.S. States & Territories
- 3 Ships at Sea



Dallas Cowboy Cheerleaders in Germany



Forrie J. Smith shares a meaningful exchange



Wilmer Valderrama at the USO Gala



NFL's Aaron Jones and Elijah Higgins visit troops at Camp Arifjan in Kuwait

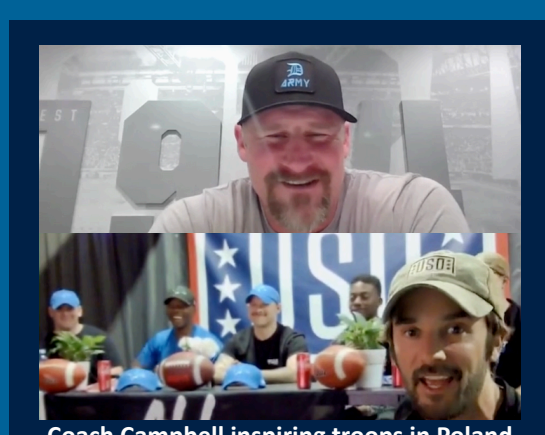
## HIGHLIGHTS

- As part of the annual NFL tour and in recognition of **Month of the Military Child**, **Minnesota Vikings** running back **Aaron Jones** and **Arizona Cardinals** tight end **Elijah Higgins** — both proud military kids — traveled to Kuwait where they led football drills, shared personal stories, and connected with troops through their shared values of discipline, teamwork, and resilience.
- The **Dallas Cowboys Cheerleaders**, stars of **Netflix's America's Sweethearts**, brought excitement to military families in Germany, with performances, kids' cheer clinics, and meet-and-greets.
- Yellowstone's Forrie J. Smith** spent time with service members at the border, sharing stories from the show, his rodeo days, and a few songs along the way.
- To celebrate the **Army's 250th birthday**, **Prime Video** and **Netflix** hosted special screenings for soldiers — Prime Video offered advance screenings of **Heads of State** with snacks, drinks, and a personalized message from star **John Cena**, while Netflix screened **The Old Guard** and served up cupcakes in honor of the milestone.
- USO Global Ambassador Wilmer Valderrama** received a special merit award at this year's **USO Gala**, joined by a star-studded lineup that included chef **Carla Hall**, **Miss America 2025 Abbie Stockard**, **MLB legend Ryan Zimmerman**, and **TLC's Monte Durham**.

## MILITARY VIRTUAL PROGRAMMING

MVP

- Detroit Lions** head coach **Dan Campbell** — whose family includes a long line of military service members — connected virtually with troops in Kuwait, Poland, and Hungary.
- Best-selling author and proud granddaughter of a WWII veteran, **Elin Hilderbrand** joined the USO's overseas Book Club to discuss **The Perfect Couple** and answer questions about her work and inspiration.



Coach Campbell inspiring troops in Poland

## T-SHIRT CAMPAIGN

The USO's annual T-shirt campaign, which runs each spring through the 4th of July, gained star-powered momentum as celebrities stepped up to show their support for those who serve.



## FLEET WEEK

## LOS ANGELES

**COMEDY & CAMARADERIE:** **Craig Robinson** brought music and laughs, performing for service members during lunch and touring Navy ships while connecting with sailors and showing genuine appreciation for their service.



Kelli Giddish aboard the USS New York



Roger Goodell personally welcomes sailors to NFL HQ



Service members pose around the NBA's iconic logo

## FROM THE ARCHIVES

FLEET WEEK EDITION

## STAGE DOOR CANTEN

In the 1940s, the stars of stage and screen united the East and West coasts under a shared goal — use their star power to boost GIs' morale. The Stage Door Canteen was an entertainment venue for American and Allied servicemen that operated in the Broadway theater district of New York City throughout World War II. While not operated by the USO, it became an iconic symbol of wartime hospitality. On opening night, 200 actresses served as hostesses and 75 actors worked as busboys. In addition to shows, the canteen offered off-duty military personnel a place to unwind, including dancing with hostesses and female entertainers, eating, and writing letters home. Food was provided free. Between 5 p.m. and midnight daily, the canteen served 200 gallons of coffee, and 5,000 cigarettes were smoked.



Legendary actress Bette Davis serves a meal to a soldier at the Stage Door Canteen in 1942



Craig Robinson hits the right note at Los Angeles Fleet Week

## NEW YORK

**GRATITUDE IN ACTION:** **Law & Order: SVU's Kelli Giddish** served lunch and visited service members at Pier 88 in Manhattan, while **Miss New Jersey** connected with troops in Staten Island.

**INDUSTRY TOURS:** While in town, sailors had the unique opportunity to tour the offices of the **NFL**, **NBA**, **MLB**, **NHL**, and **Warner Music**. **NFL Commissioner Roger Goodell** and **NHL Commissioner Gary Bettman** made special appearances to personally thank service members for their dedication and service.

**BROADWAY NIGHT OUT:** Service members attended a performance of the **Tony-nominated musical Operation Mincemeat** during the week's festivities. Before the show, they were invited to a recreation of the historic **Stage Door Canteen** at Sardi's for a free drink, followed by an exclusive USO meet-and-greet with the cast at the Golden Theatre.



Sailors proudly flash their Operation Mincemeat playbills



Service members with the cast of Operation Mincemeat



Sailors enjoying hospitality at Sardi's recreation of the Stage Door Canteen

## FLEET WEEK ENVY? YOU'RE IN LUCK.

**Philadelphia's Homecoming 250** — a Fleet Week-style celebration honoring the 250th anniversary of the Navy and Marine Corps — is happening **October 9–16**. If you have talent or a project interested in participating, reach out: [entertainment@uso.org](mailto:entertainment@uso.org)